

A Replicated Full 2^3 Factorial Investigation of Freezing Time*

Testing the Mpemba Effect

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April 4, 2025

This study investigates the Mpemba effect—the counterintuitive hypothesis that hot water may freeze faster than cold water—using a replicated 2^3 full factorial design. The experiment explores three factors: initial water temperature (room temperature or hot), solution density (low or high), and container material (glass or plastic), with eight treatment combinations and two replicates each. Results show that all three main factors significantly affect freezing time, with hot water exhibiting the largest effect of +23.125 minutes. However, none of the interaction effects were statistically significant. These findings suggest that under controlled conditions, hot water freezes more slowly than cold water, providing no evidence in support of the Mpemba effect.

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*Code and data are available at: <https://github.com/HaoweiFan0912/mpemba-freezing-experiment.git>

1 Introduction

The Mpemba effect refers to the phenomenon in which hot water may freeze faster than cold water under certain specific conditions. This effect was first observed and reported by Tanzanian student Erasto Mpemba in the 1960s. Although the phenomenon is counterintuitive, it has indeed been observed in some experimental studies. Nevertheless, the Mpemba effect remains highly controversial. Some scholars argue that the phenomenon lacks rigorous experimental control, uniform standards, and reproducibility across different studies, raising doubts about its scientific validity. On the other hand, some researchers support the existence of the Mpemba effect under specific conditions, suggesting that the thermodynamic mechanisms behind this effect might provide new insights into the nonequilibrium behavior of quantum systems.

The objective of this experiment is to investigate the scientific validity of the Mpemba effect by comparing differences in freezing times of water at various initial temperatures under constant spatial and temperature conditions. Additionally, two other potential influencing factors—solution density and container material—are included in the experiment to comprehensively examine their main effects on freezing time, as well as possible significant interaction effects among these factors. This allows exploration of whether such interactions are significant and whether they might contribute to the mechanisms underlying the Mpemba effect.

This experiment employs a replicated 2^3 full factorial experimental design. The three factors, each with two levels, are initial water temperature (room temperature around 17°C vs. hot water at approximately 45°C), solution density (pure water vs. sugar solution with 5 ml sucrose), and container material (glass vs. plastic cup). This results in eight experimental conditions, each replicated twice, totaling sixteen experiments. To minimize nuisance variables, the experiments were conducted in a uniform freezer environment at -17°C . Each trial simultaneously included two cups of water to minimize cross-interference between different temperature conditions. Observations began 1.5 hours after placing the water samples into the freezer, with checks conducted every 5 minutes. The criterion for freezing was the absence of liquid water movement when the cup was gently shaken, upon which the freezing time was recorded.

This experiment took place at home, which led to some limitations. The differences between conditions were broad because of what was available. For example, “hot” and “room temperature” water were judged using household methods, not exact measurements. To change the solution density, I added or didn’t add 5 ml of sugar—no finer control was used. I measured freezing time by listening for the sound of moving water. This method is simple but not precise.

2 Data and Methodology

Table 1 presents the observed data from the replicated 2^3 full factorial experiment. Each run represents a distinct experimental condition determined by the combination of three factors: Factor A (initial water temperature; -1 for room temperature $\sim 17^\circ\text{C}$, +1 for hot water $\sim 45^\circ\text{C}$), Factor B (solution density; -1 for pure water, +1 for sugar solution with 5ml sucrose), and Factor C (container material; -1 for plastic cup, +1 for glass cup). Columns labeled AB, AC, BC, and ABC represent the corresponding interaction terms. The columns y_1 and y_2 indicate the freezing times (in minutes) recorded for two replicates of each run, and y_{mean} is the average of these two measurements.

Table 1: Design matrix and observed freezing times from the experiment. A, B, and C represent initial water temperature (+1 = hot), solution density (+1 = high density), and cup material (+1 = glass), with interaction terms (AB, AC, BC, ABC), and freezing times y_1 , y_2 , and their mean. The longest freezing time occurred with hot water, high density, and a plastic cup; the shortest with room-temperature water, low density, and a glass cup.

Run	A	B	C	AB	AC	BC	ABC	y_1	y_2	y_{mean}
1	-1	-1	-1	1	1	1	-1	135	135	135.0
2	-1	-1	1	1	-1	-1	1	120	125	122.5
3	-1	1	-1	-1	1	-1	1	150	155	152.5
4	-1	1	1	-1	-1	1	-1	140	135	137.5
5	1	-1	-1	-1	-1	1	1	165	165	165.0
6	1	-1	1	-1	1	-1	-1	145	140	142.5
7	1	1	-1	1	-1	-1	-1	175	170	172.5
8	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	155	165	160.0

The factorial effects presented in Table 2 were computed from these observed data. First, the effect estimates were obtained by calculating the difference between average responses at the positive (+1) and negative (-1) levels of each factor or interaction: $\text{Effect} = \bar{y}_+ - \bar{y}_-$ where $\bar{y}_+$ and $\bar{y}_-$ represent the average response for the positive and negative levels of each factorial effect.

Next, the variance of each run was calculated using the two replicated measurements: $s_{\text{run}}^2 = \frac{(y_1 - y_2)^2}{2}$. These variances were pooled to estimate the experimental error variance: $s^2 = \frac{\sum_{i=1}^8 s_{\text{run},i}^2}{8}$. The standard error (SE) of each effect estimate was calculated as: $SE = \frac{s}{2}$ where s is the square root of the pooled variance s^2 .

A t-value for testing the null hypothesis $H_0 : \text{Effect} = 0$ was then computed: $t_{\text{eff}} = \frac{\text{Effect}}{SE}$. The corresponding p-value was obtained from a two-sided t-test with 8 degrees of freedom: $\text{p-value} = 2 \cdot P(|t_8| > |t_{\text{eff}}|)$. Finally, the 95% confidence intervals for each factorial effect were

calculated as: $CI_{95\%} = \text{Effect} \pm t_{0.975,8} \cdot SE$ where $t_{0.975,8}$ is the critical t-value at the 95% confidence level with 8 degrees of freedom.

Table 2: Summary of estimated main and interaction effects with standard errors, t-values, p-values, and 95% confidence intervals. Effects A, B, and C are statistically significant with p-values < 0.05 . All interaction effects are small and not significant.

Effect	Estimate	SE	t_value	p_value	CI_lower	CI_upper
A	23.125	1.875	12.333	0.000	18.801	27.449
B	14.375	1.875	7.667	0.000	10.051	18.699
C	-15.625	1.875	-8.333	0.000	-19.949	-11.301
AB	-1.875	1.875	-1.000	0.347	-6.199	2.449
AC	-1.875	1.875	-1.000	0.347	-6.199	2.449
BC	1.875	1.875	1.000	0.347	-2.449	6.199
ABC	3.125	1.875	1.667	0.134	-1.199	7.449

In addition, to visually observe the main and interaction effects of each factor, a linear model was fitted and a half-normal plot was generated (Figure 1):

$$\hat{y}_{\text{mean}} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 A + \beta_2 B + \beta_3 C + \beta_4 AB + \beta_5 AC + \beta_6 BC + \beta_7 ABC$$

In this fitted linear model, $\hat{y}_{\text{mean}}$ represents the predicted average freezing time. The intercept term β_0 corresponds to the average response when all factors are at their low level (-1). The coefficients β_1 , β_2 , and β_3 represent half of the main effects of factors A (initial temperature), B (sugar content), and C (cup material), respectively. The coefficients β_4 , β_5 , and β_6 represent half of the two-way interaction effects between these factors (AB, AC, and BC), while β_7 corresponds to half of the three-way interaction effect (ABC).

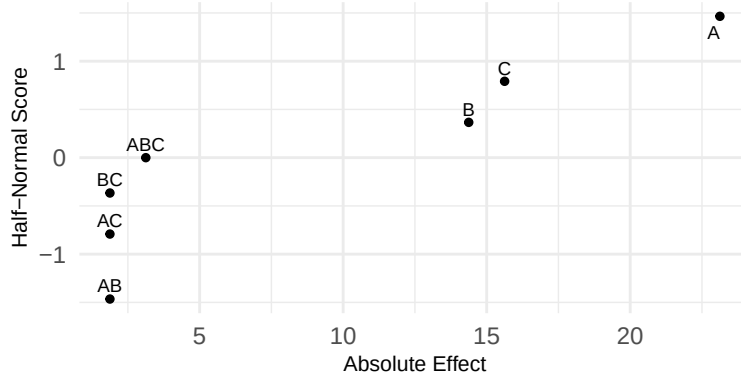


Figure 1: Half-normal plot of absolute effects from the freezing experiment. Points farther from the lower-left corner (A, B, C) represent larger and likely significant effects. Interaction effects are clustered near the origin, indicating insignificance.

3 Conclusions

The results of this 2^3 factorial experiment demonstrate that all three main factors—A (initial water temperature), B (solution density), and C (container material)—have notable effects on freezing time.

- Factor A (Temperature) had the largest effect of +23.125 minutes, with a p-value of 0.000 and a 95% confidence interval of [18.801, 27.449]. This highly significant result indicates that hot water freezes much slower than room-temperature water.
- Factor B (Sugar content) showed an effect of +14.375 minutes, also statistically significant ($p = 0.000$, CI: [10.051, 18.699]), confirming that sugar delays the freezing process.
- Factor C (Cup material) had a significant negative effect of -15.625 minutes ($p = 0.000$, CI: [-19.949, -11.301]), showing that water in plastic cups freezes faster than in glass cups.

Regarding interaction effects:

- AB, AC, and BC each had small estimated effects of ± 1.875 minutes with p-values of 0.347, and their confidence intervals all include zero. These results suggest no significant interaction between those factor pairs.
- ABC, the three-way interaction, had an estimated effect of +3.125 minutes ($p = 0.134$, CI: [-1.199, 7.449]), which is also statistically insignificant.

These conclusions are further supported by the half-normal plot, where A, B, and C appear clearly far from the lower-left cluster, while the interaction effects are tightly grouped, indicating insignificance. Additionally, the rule of thumb that any effect more than 2 to 3 times its standard error is unlikely to result from random chance also supports these findings. For example, Factor A has a t-value of 12.333 (effect = 23.125, SE = 1.875), and Factors B and C have t-values of 7.667 and 8.333 respectively, all far exceeding this threshold. In contrast, the interaction terms have t-values close to or below 1.000, showing weak or no statistical evidence.

The Mpemba effect refers to the observation that hot water may freeze faster than cold water. In this study, however, Factor A (initial water temperature) showed a highly significant positive effect of +23.125 minutes, meaning hot water froze considerably slower than cooler water. Given the statistical significance and direction of the effect, this experiment provides no evidence supporting the Mpemba effect. Moreover, even when accounting for the two additional factors (sugar and cup material), none of the interaction effects involving temperature—namely AB (-1.875), AC (-1.875), and ABC (+3.125)—were statistically significant. Therefore, we cannot conclude that the interactions between water temperature and these two factors play a meaningful role in producing the Mpemba effect.